

WHIDBEY ISLAND HORSE COUNCIL
MEETING MINUTES
10/8/25

The meeting was called to order at 6:30 pm by coordinator Sally Garratt. Eleven people were present including guests Kyle (from Bell's Farm) and Scottish (Rheda's husband).

The discussion regarding the "Mission Statement" for the Horse Council was tabled until the next meeting because Leslie was not present.

Rheda reported that Thora, from the Coupeville Chamber of Commerce, was working on formatting and organizing the Horse Resource Directory for Whidbey Island. Rheda will keep in contact with her and report any progress.

Jennifer and Connie reported that they have contacted several businesses regarding information to be used for an survey of the economic impact of equine activities on Whidbey Island. This survey would expand and follow up on the initial survey done by the Conservation district in 2015. The businesses were reluctant to share information without the project being sponsored by a known and reputable organization. A discussion ensued regarding who we could partner with to give the project credibility and to help with the resources necessary to accomplish our goals. Several entities were suggested including Skagit Community College and the Conservation District. Jennifer, Connie and Leslie will followup on trying to find a Partner for this project.

The remainder of the meeting was dedicated to a discussion of the use of Bell's Farm as an equestrian facility...considering the restrictions placed on the property by the Land Trust. Rheda presented a power point explanation of her vision of how to make that possible. Her vision includes making the property primarily an agricultural business but with the focus on sustainable horse related activities. She would include multiple horse disciplines both western and English and focus on creating a community center for equine activities. Rheda would provide horse boarding using a "track system" which would make the experience for horses as near to a natural environment as possible. She would include community horse events using both indoor and outdoor arenas and potentially an outdoor cross country course. Rheda will coordinate with the pony club to determine how that would work. She will also contact the Land Trust to see if the use of the property in this manner would be possible considering the conservation easements now on the property. The discussion included many questions and suggestions and Rheda will follow up on moving this project forward.

The meeting was adjourned at 8pm. The next meeting will be held on November 5, 2025 at the Race Road Fire Station.